Research Project Guidelines

As part of the course requirements, students are required to complete a group-based empirical research project. The primary objective is to select a high-impact, peer-reviewed paper (empirical, or theoretical with an empirical component) in development economics, replicate its core findings, and execute a substantive extension suitable for submission to an academic journal. The general purpose of the project is to provide students with an opportunity to identify, replicate, and address a research problem in development economics using empirical methods. It also aims to develop collaborative research skills, academic writing, and presentation abilities.

General Information[1]

(i) **Group Size:** 3 members.

(ii) **Paper Selection:** Choose a peer-reviewed empirical paper published in a recognized top economics journal (for example, JDE, World Development, Review of Development Economics, AER, QJE etc.). Ensure that either raw data is publicly available or suitable micro-level datasets exist to replicate the core analysis. Select research papers published within the last 10 years.

(iii) **Replication:** You need to use the same dataset used in the paper to replicate the empirical findings (tables and figures) of the main paper. Trust me! IT IS NOT EASY.

(iv) **Extension:** After you successfully replicate the paper, find ways to extend it. An extension is not merely adding a control variable, changing the dependent variable, or running a minor functional form tweak. It must address a fundamental gap in the existing literature. For example, you may find that the empirical model can be applied to a different Geographic & Institutional Context; Sub-National Context; Different Time Period; For Demographic Groups; Alternative Econometric Estimation; Updated Data Source etc. Whatever path you take, motivate it from the research gap and verify that it is not already studied.

(v) **Proposal Deadline:** Each group is required to submit a **1-page** project proposal indicating the research paper details they have chosen, the dataset it uses, and the names of the group members, on or before **15 September 2026**. **Submit PDF copy of proposal only in the Google Classroom folder named "Project Proposal".** Please mention course name and contact email & phone number of group leader.

(vi) **Replication Deadline:** Groups should submit their replication work by **17 October 2026**. **Submit PDF copy** of your **replication work** only in the **Google Classroom folder named**

[1] I will inform you in class in case of any changes in dates and deadlines.

"Replication Submission". The replication work should contain a title, introduction section, data section, methodology section, and replication section where you will produce your replicated figures and tables. In case, the work does not match the published tables and figures, then add an extra section explaining the plausible reasons for it.

(vii) **Final Presentations will be held during the first one and a half weeks of November** in the Development Economics Class. Presentation duration is maximum 15 minutes (including Q&A). Everyone or only one group member may present.

(viii) **Final Project Submission: 14th November 2026 (Saturday) by 05:00 PM IST.**

(ix) **Submit PDF copies** of your **final work** only in the **Google Classroom folder named "Final Submission"**.

(x) The report should be prepared in Times New Roman, 12-point font, with 1.5-line spacing and margins of 2.54 cm on all sides. Page numbers and section numbers must be clearly indicated. The project should have names of all members and the contribution of each member in the final project.

(xi) Students may use any standard statistical software they are comfortable with.

(xii) **Writing Tip:** Construct short sentences in active voice. Research papers are written in the present tense except when you state a past fact when you use past tense. Try to follow this rule, writing will be relatively easy.

(xiii) **Plagiarism Policy:** Plagiarism including direct copying of text, uncredited paraphrasing, submitting work generated entirely by external tools will result in an immediate score of ZERO (0) for the entire project team. All submissions will undergo automated plagiarism checks.

(xiv) **AI Use Policy:** The use of **Generative AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot)** is permitted only as a supportive assistance tool. You can use it for: (i) Ideation & brainstorming. (ii) Assisting for literature search. (iii) Cleaning software codes or troubleshooting syntax errors. (iv) Correcting grammar and sentence construction. **Students should self-declare the usage of AI in the aforementioned areas.**

Structure of Final Submission Project

Final Project Submission is due by 14th November 2026 (Saturday) by 05:00 PM IST.

1. **Title Page** with details of authors and their affiliation
2. **Abstract** (150-200 words)
3. **Introduction** (you can borrow the introduction from the replication work submitted in October)
4. **Literature Review** (you can borrow the literature review from the replication work and also may add papers to motivate your replication work)
5. **Extension** (gap in the literature, motivation for extension and its relevance)
6. **Data and Methodology** (you can borrow it from the replication work and add any extensions that you do)
7. **Results and Discussion** (Try to contrast your results to that of the replication work with explanations wherever necessary)
8. **Policy Implications (if any)**
9. **Conclusion**
10. **References** (APA style). You also need to do in-text citations wherever required. Do not make universal statements without proper citations.
11. **Figures and Tables** should be placed within the body of the text. Tables numbered and titled above. Figures numbered and titled below. For conventions check how tables and figures are labelled in standard economics journal articles.
12. **Appendix** (if any).

Grading and Rubric (Total Marks is 40)

Component	Weightage (Marks)	Description
Replication work	15	Appropriate motivation. Selection of relevant papers, logical flow of concepts and ideas. The project explicitly maps out the theoretical mechanisms linking the causes to primary outcomes. The replication correctly specifies baseline econometric equations and notation. It accurately reproduces published tables and figures. In case of any discrepancy, the project clearly explains any divergence.
Empirical Extension	10	Proper identification of gap in the literature for extension, motivation for extension and its relevance. Quality of empirical extension, analysis, interpretation of findings, robustness checks, and policy implication is explicitly evaluated.
Guidelines, Writing & Formatting	5	Project has followed all stated guidelines. Academic writing style, organization of sections, proper formatting as per instructions, adequate labelling of tables, figures, references done correctly.
Presentation	10	Clearly explains the research paper with proper motivation, existing evidence, and results.
Total Marks	**40**	